8.4 Activities: word problems

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1. Problems without numbers

You need: nothing, or paper.

Read him a word problem with the numbers taken out: “Some children are going on a school trip. Each bus holds a certain number of children. How many buses are needed?” Ask: “What would you need to know? What kind of sum would you do?” No arithmetic at all.

This trains steps 1–3 (read, picture, plan) without any fear of getting a number wrong.

Talk about it: “If there were 100 children and buses of 30, would the answer be exactly right, or would you need to round?”

2. Write your own

You need: paper, a sum such as 4 × €2,50.

Give him a bare sum and ask him to write a story around it. Then swap: you write one, he solves it, and you try his. Silly stories are welcome (four dragons each buy a €2,50 ice cream). Then give him a story with a **two-step** sum: 3 × €2 + €5.

Talk about it: “What words in your story told the reader to multiply?”

3. Spot the extra

You need: the problems in practice Set D, or any word problem with extra information.

Before solving, he crosses out every number or fact that isn’t needed. Read it out: “Tom is 12 years old.” “Does his age help us know how long the ride is?” Make it a game: you hide one piece of useless information in a problem and he finds it.

Talk about it: “Why do you think test makers put extra information in sometimes?” (Real life is full of it; part of maths is choosing what matters.)

4. Act it out

You need: coins, cups, toy figures, Lego, a tape measure.

Pick one problem from the practice sets and act it out with objects. Sharing 27 children into groups of 4? Use 27 pieces of pasta. Change from €10? Use real coins. Physically doing it calms the stress response and makes the structure visible.

Talk about it: “What did acting it out show you that the text didn’t?”

5. Timetable trip

You need: a real bus or train timetable (*dienstregeling*) from an app or the station, or a 9292 route.

Plan a pretend (or real) day trip: when must you leave home to be at the beach (*strand*) by 11:00? How long is the journey? If you miss a bus, how long do you wait? Let him lead and you just ask questions.

Talk about it: “What could go wrong on the trip, and how would you change the plan?”

6. Problem of the day at dinner

You need: nothing.

Once a week, someone at dinner brings a real word problem from their day: “I drove 23 km to work and back, five days. How far is that in a week?” Everyone solves it their own way and says how. There is no prize for being first; the interesting part is the different methods.

Talk about it: “Did anyone use a different method? Which one would you use next time?”

Conversation prompts for any day

- “Can you say this question in your own words?”
- “What would a good drawing of this look like?”
- “What do you already know? What do you need to find out?”
- “Does your answer make sense? Would you believe it if a friend said it?”
- “What would you do first?”